

How it Works

The artist creates his painting

He then archives them on a CD

These CDs are sold through retail stores

CDs are also retailed through Web sites

Thus are generated enquiries about CDs

Paintings are sold. The artist's work is longer restricted to geographic boundaries

faster than snail mail, though," says Mehrotra.

The Internet, therefore, was a natural progression. He created a self-titled Web site, for which he learned to author HTML pages. "It was great fun," he remembers.

It all began when, in the late '80s, Mehrotra began experimenting with digital lithographs, something he would develop into a fine art, and a constant revenue stream. He was in New York then.

Later, in the '90s, he created exquisite works of art using both two-and-three-dimensional software. Adobe Photoshop and Fractal Design Painter were his easels; his Wacom cordless pen and a digitiser, his brushes.

And A CD Takes Birth

The CD-ROM would seem a run-of-the-mill idea, but when Mehrotra pioneered it in 2001, it was nothing less than revolutionary.

Even today, no other Indian artist has developed a CD-ROM. Mehrotra is quite reticent about it, though.

"I have done a lot of diverse work since 1967. I felt I should preserve my work in a medium different than a glossy catalogue. The CD-ROM idea came primarily with that objective in mind."

Mehrotra also wanted it to be interactive. A CD-ROM would be the best medium, then, given his needs. The medium, he hoped,

The CD-ROM is an important step in making people aware of my work... I am happy that several artists are now going digital.

Jaideep Mehrotra

would make his work accessible to a larger section of art connoisseurs and peers, both Indian and from across the world.

The CD itself is a digital journey into the artist's life. Divided into sections that detail his life, his work is in the form of paintings and lithographs.

It even includes his poster design for the Dev Benegal film *Split Wide Open*. It then records his views in the form of newspaper and television interviews.

"It has my work from 1984 onwards. Each of the paintings includes a description of the work along with the attached price, if it is still available for sale. You can find my sculptures and other art work too."

Interestingly, Mehrotra authored the CD on his own for both Windows and Apple platforms compatibility.

Veteran actor and one of the early adopters of the Web in India, Shammi Kapoor, launched the CD in 2001, and Mehrotra has since sold over 300 CDs, a unique achievement for something that is as niche as an art CD-ROM. Mehrotra later sold through mid-day.com (the Web site of a popular evening newspaper in Mumbai) to sell the CD, a move that resulted in a lot of enquiries from the US about his work.

Why CD-ROM?

Mehrotra feels that a CD-ROM is important for any individual or

Online Art Will Be Big... Soon

Experts say technology will only enhance the art experience. It is only a matter of time before artists in India begin to process, catalogue and archive their works digitally. Art critic Jasmine Shah Varma believes the Internet has opened a new vista for Indian artists.

Dinesh Vazirani, co-founder of Saffronart.com's India chapter, says the Net has helped promote art in a big way. "It has provided an objective platform for artists to display their works to a global audience."

He adds that the Net is increasingly being used by artists to experiment and usher in new movements in terms of style.

Mehrotra is probably the first Indian artist who experimented with digital media, but others are following suit. Says Vazirani: "Digital art is not a hot trend due to lack of awareness, and due to the misconception that digital art can be reproduced a million times over. This has resulted in a cautious approach towards this medium."

Shah Varma, meanwhile, feels that technology has some way to go before it we can confidently say that the time for it has arrived.

"It is a relatively new field, and only two other major contemporary artists—Akbar Padamsee and Gulammohammed Shaikh—have experimented with this medium," she says. "The awareness of digital art and use of technology in art among art buyers is practically non-existent, and art buyers are more comfortable with traditional media like oil and watercolour."

"It is hard to say whether the market for digital art will thrive in India in the current scenario."

But she is also certain that technology is making inroads into the field of artistic creation. "Many artists have been using video and computers as media to make and display art. Gradually, we will see greater use of technology, but it is hard to predict how soon and to what extent."